CHAPTER 44

# LIFE IN ONE DAY

It’s a phone call. A short one. Andrew Strauss is the director of cricket now and he has some news to deliver to me. England are no longer going to consider me for selection for one-day cricket. They are going to move on and look for other bowlers while allowing me to play Test cricket. I do not understand the decision, nor the reasoning behind it. I am the all-time highest wicket taker in England’s white ball history. I am still bowling well. There is still so much to do, so much more to achieve. Does he think I’m reaching the end of my career, at 33? He must do, because he’s putting an end to one side of it. I feel from his tone that he is suggesting maybe trying to get another couple of years out of my Test career.

History and experience will tell you this is rational and realistic planning, but I know, in my body, that I am nowhere near the end. The response that comes from within is instinctive and survivalistic. I have reached the place I have against many odds. It goes against every choice I have made in my life up until this point to accept that I should stand down. The way the game has taught me to evolve, to keep fighting, searching for those deep reserves, each time finding I can go further than I’d imagined.

I don’t know then that this will be a blessing, nor can I accept his quite logical reasoning that it will help prolong my Test career by managing my workloads, nor does it soften the blow that he is doing the same thing to Broady. Since the Flower team that went to Bavaria and beyond, there are only three remaining; myself, Broad and Cook. We have developed a closeness, in part due to the sheer shared experience, and a tendency to diffuse the pressure with play, bonding us together with an understanding that is unexplainable to anyone outside. We have become close friends – in touch through the days, communicating on not just cricket and regularly